decided to intervene. Acting without orders, in 1811 he raided the plantation and took away seventy-six men, women and children, ‘all of whom declared that they had been stolen or forcibly carried away by Moplahs and others from South Malabar, Cochin and Travancore, and transported to Mr Brown’s plantation at Anjaracandy’. Brown then laid a complaint against Baber and won, with the court ordering that all the slaves should be returned to him except for six of the children. However, when the case reached the Supreme Court in Calcutta a year later, the judgment was reversed and it was pronounced that ‘Mr Baber was fully justified in the measure he had adopted’.[9]

Thomas Baber’s actions led to a ban on the import and sale of slaves throughout the EICo’s territories, even if the institution itself was only finally banned in India in 1843.[10] Ironically, abolitionist pressure on slave-owners in Muslim states such as Awadh was one of several reforming measures that contributed to the great sepoy revolt of 1857. Of course, it can be argued that the system of indentured labour introduced into India by the British at this same time was simply slavery by another name. And it could further be argued that slavery within Islam had one distinct advantage over slavery by caste, which was that it held out the prospect of liberty through conversion. But this raises the tricky issue of forced conversion, because there is no question but that over the course of several centuries thousands of Hindus, Buddhists and Jains had to face a choice between Islam or enslavement and that many converted.

After Independence this issue of religious violence perpetrated by Muslim rulers and warlords became to all intents a taboo subject, with what were then the younger generation of historians such as Dr Romila Thapar and Dr Irfan Habib condemning what they saw as simplistic interpretations of the past and focusing instead on socio-